This is Where it Ends

By Marieke Nijkamp

PRINCIPAL TRENTON: *(at a podium addressing the entire school body on the 1st day of 2nd Semester)* **(Pg 5)** Here at Opportunity, we pride ourselves on shaping the doctors, lawyers, and politicians of tomorrow. And it's the choices you make now that will determine your future.

AUTUMN: **(Pg 5-6)** My brother would tell me that Principal Trenton's words are truer than I think; that it's up to me to make my future the best it can be. For me, college is the only way out of this misery, and Dad sure as hell isn't going to pay my ride. Not to study dance.

FATHER: Look what happened to your mother. . .

AUTUMN: As if I haven't counted the days, hours, minutes since Mom's accident.

FATHER: Dance took everything from her. No daughter of mine is going into that business. Not if I can stop it.

AUTUMN: So he tries to stop me—every day. And with Mom gone, there's no one to stop him. Not from drinking. Not from hitting me. There's no one to keep our family from falling apart.

PRINCIPAL TRENTON: **(Pg 4)** . . . it's all a matter of the decisions you make, today and every day. Your behavior reflects not only on yourself but also on your parents, your family, and your school.

AUTUMN: **(Pg 30)** A set of doors to my left opens. blond locks under a black knit cap. That's the first thing I notice—the unruly hair that frames a too-familiar face. [NOTE: Attributed to another student, Sylv, in the novel] **(Pg 42)** *Tyler.* My brother.

TYLER: **(Pg 30)** *(with a handgun pointed at her head, he calls out in a sing-song voice)* Principal Trenton, I have a question. *(he fires)*

INTRODUCTION

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AUTUMN: (Pg 35) The stage is a mess of people congregating around Principal Trenton—Mr. Jameson, everyone's favorite English teacher, tries to stem the blood flow, except she's hit in the head, and it's not blood but brains. [NOTE: Attributed to another student, Sylv, in the novel]

TYLER: (Pg 60) I have no issue with most of you, so I'd rather you don't force me to waste my bullets.

AUTUMN: (Pg 34) The room is swept up in panic. Screams echo in my ears. Teachers standing near the doors try to approach Tyler, but he picks them off methodically, like everyone who gets too close. **(Pg 37)** I hear gasps and cries and screams. There's death, there's dying, and there's blood everywhere. [NOTE: Attributed to another student, Sylv, in the novel]

TYLER: *(he struts to the stage)* **(Pg 71-72)** I liked it here once. Opportunity High. Opportunity. It sounds so hopeful. I wanted to fit in here. Instead, I lost everything. All of you with your perfect lives. Do you know what losing feels like? Do you care?

AUTUMN: (Pg 57-58) Fear and survival are two sides of the same coin. Dad taught me that. These last two years, he proved it again and again and again. Terror is our strongest force because we're only afraid when we have something to lose. **(Pg 73)** I don't know what Ty wants, but if they try to stop him, this'll only get worse.

TYLER: If you cooperate, some of you might go home today. All you have to do is listen carefully. No screaming, no running, no phones. Today, you'll all listen.

AUTUMN: **(Pg 42)** My brother, who cared for my bruises when Dad couldn't contain his grief. Who helped me dance. Once, he caught Dad's belt on his bare arm to stop it from coming down on me. Afterward, Tyler cracked a joke and tousled my hair. He is the only real family I have. *It* can't be him.

TYLER: (Pg 87-88) *(smiling and grandiose)* Now then. Good. To survive, you must know who your friends are. You must know who you can trust. And you must know how to stop caring.

AUTUMN: His smile was just like Dad's—cold. A couple nights ago, Ty stood by while Dad showed me that the love he once had for dance, for me, died along with Mom. Yesterday,

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Ty laughed through his tears. When he tended my bruises, he told me there was nothing that made him happier than to see me dance. It reminded him of when Mom was alive and we'd go see her performances. He said that even though he'd never felt the extremes of Dad's anger, he'd already lost so much. We both had. I wanted to believe him. He's my brother.

TYLER: (Pg 89) Lesson one: don't get attached and you won't get hurt. *(He fires)*

AUTUMN: Without a second glance, without so much as a blink, he pulls the trigger and shoots Mr. Jameson.

TYLER: (Pg 102) Do you know what it feels like to lose everything you hold dear? Your family? Your girlfriend? For your *entire town* to turn against you too? I'm reclaiming Opportunity. Your lives are mine. And you **will** pay attention. *(tapping the barrel of the gun against his chin he speaks softly while pacing back and forth)* **(Pg 104)** I thought my family at least cared about me. But you corrupted them. You left nothing for me *(beat)* Wouldn't you agree, Autumn? *(silence)* **(Pg 107)** *(in a singsong voice)* Would it help if I gave you an incentive to make the right decision?

AUTUMN: He jumps off the stage and paces in front of the students like he's deciding who to pick for his basketball team in PE. **(Pg 109-110)** He leans over and drags a girl by her baseball jersey over the row of seats. She's young—a sophomore maybe. Too young to die. The auditorium may be big enough to hold a thousand students, but it's too small to hide just one.

TYLER: (Pg 113-114) *(he calls out)* It's easy, Autumn. Come out or I'll pick off the entire school. *(gunshots punctuate each word)* Just. Like. This.

AUTUMN: *(to audience)* **(Pg 124-125)** Every time I blink, I see Nyah's face being torn apart by a bullet. If anyone can get through to him, it's me. I have to try . . . *(to Tyler)* Tyler. *(clears her throat and speaks louder)* Tyler. I'm here. *(to audience)* **(Pg 136)** I'm staring at a stranger. This is not the same person who showed me the abandoned shed where I could dance in secret. This isn't the same person who bought me pointe shoes. He may look and sound like Tyler, but this is not the same person.

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TYLER: **(Pg 134)** *(sarcastically)* Do you expect me to shout at you from across the room? Did your mother not raise you better than that?

AUTUMN: **(Pg 136)** When I reach the stage, the full horror hits me. The bodies of half a dozen teachers lie up there. *(to Tyler)* Why, Tyler?

TYLER: **(Pg 137)** *(grabbing a fistful of Autumn's hair and pulling her on stage – his gaze devoid of humanity)* You think you are so special, don't you? Do you even care about anyone anymore? Or do you only care about yourself? *(He holds the gun to her face)*

AUTUMN: Please don't. *(whispers)* I love you. **(Pg 146-147)** You're my brother. You're my best friend. You're everything to me. What happened to us, Ty? I lost as much as you did. But you made me believe fulfilling Mom's dream—*my* dream—was still possible.

TYLER: *(blinks)* Believe in **your** dream?

AUTUMN: To get out of here.

TYLER: *(begins to laugh, louder and louder)* I wanted to be your excuse to stay home. But you pushed me away. **(Pg 148)** You told me there was nothing keeping you here. Not even me. *(the laughing turns to sobbing)* It's your fault. *(gestures grandly)* All of this, is your fault. *(he fires again into the crowd)*

AUTUMN: **(Pg 153)** I know it's my fault. *(softly)* Not a day goes by when I don't miss Mom. I wish I could go back and redo that day. But I can't. I ***can't***. I can only keep doing what she wanted me to do, and she wanted me to dance, Ty.

TYLER: **(Pg 161)** *(seething)* I hate you. You never cared about me. You never cared about any of us. You only ever cared about dance.

AUTUMN: *(wincing)* I want to contradict him, but I can't. Dance is beauty. Dance is compassion, honesty. The only way I've ever known how to share my feelings is through dance.

TYLER: *(points the gun again at Autumn)* So dance. You wanted a stage? Take it!

AUTUMN: *(assumes 5th position and begins to dance with trembling hands and tears pouring down her face) (to the audience)* **(Pg 175)** They say your life flashes in front of your eyes right before you die. As I wait for Ty to pull the trigger, no memories overtake me. No last wishes or if-onlys. *(she can't dance anymore, and crumples)* When Dad was at his worst,

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he'd call me every name he could think of and wouldn't stop until he felt like he'd won. Ty is worse. His eyes are wild and unrecognizable.

TYLER: *(shaking his head)* I thought you understood the loneliness and the loss. I thought that was why you wanted to get out—to fight back. To ***win***. *(facing the auditorium, he punctuates each word with a gunshot)* **(Pg 182)** I. Will. Not. Let. You. Go.

AUTUMN: *(grabbing his arm, she steps between him and the students in the auditorium)* **(Pg 260)** You won't kill me. We're family. That must count for something. *(he brushes Autumn aside roughly, takes aim and fires at her) (Autumn drops to the ground -- long beat) (to audience)* **(Pg 270)** When Ty pointed the gun at me, he broke me. I didn't need to die for him to kill me. He simply lowered his gun and pulled the trigger. And his bullet tore my knee to shreds.

TYLER: *(with a complete lack of emotion)* **(Pg 260)** Our family was everything to me once. *(he puts the gun to his own temple)* I just don't want to be alone anymore . . . *(he fires) (long beat)*

AUTUMN: *(to audience – she composes herself and speaks slowly)* **(Pg 280)** We are not better because we survived. We are not brighter or more deserving. We are not stronger. But we are here. We are here, and this day will never leave us. *[NOTE: Attributed to another student, Fareed, in the novel]*

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